



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Living Water School
School Website: <https://thelwschool.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL**Executive Summary**

The Living Water School MD 20744 presents a robust Classical education orientation integrated with a distinctive Sudbury-inspired, student-led element. Public-facing materials consistently emphasize classical elements (Trivium, Latin, logic, rhetoric, Great Books/Living Books, Socratic seminars) alongside a Christ-centered, Biblical worldview, and deliberate communal practices (worship, Bible study, family partnership). While the school highlights traditional classical aims—virtue, wisdom, Great Books, liberal arts, and Socratic pedagogy—it also foregrounds a democratic, student-led dimension (Sudbury model) that introduces some non-classical practice into the learning environment. This combination yields a generally Classical profile with notable non-classical threads.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL.

Key drivers of the assessment: - Strong classical curriculum signals (Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric, Latin, logic, rhetoric, classical literature, Great Books/Classic literature references) and explicit mention of Socratic seminars and rhetorical training. - Clear religious/metaphysical foundations (Christ-centered, Biblical worldview, worship, Bible study) that align with classical criteria. - Explicit attention to formation of character, virtue, and the “whole person” through a philosophically classical framing, even as the school accommodates a democratic, student-led component. - Evidence of a formal accreditation framework (Middle States) and a structured, age-phase Trivium model (Little Springs, Creeks, Rivers, Bays) to organize curriculum and pedagogy.

Notes on needle-moving considerations: - The integration of a Sudbury-inspired, student-led model introduces non-classical pedagogy signals (per the classical lexicon), which places Element 2 and Element 4 nuances toward the middle of the classical spectrum. However, the weight of explicit classical curriculum, pedagogy, and community practices remains strong enough to maintain an overall CLASSICAL designation.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school identifies itself as Christ-centered and Christian, grounding its mission in Biblical principles and worship. Public materials emphasize worship and Bible study as integral to community life (for example, The Village gathering includes worship and Bible study). - Worldview is explicitly described as Biblical, with the school foregrounding a Biblical worldview as part of its educational approach (Worldview based on Biblical teachings). - Accredited online classical Christian framing is clearly stated in a primary description of Living Water School as a “classical Christian school” that blends classical education with Christian values.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Christ-centered, Bible study, worship, Biblical teachings, Christian principles, theology-related language, sacred, worship/worship services, world-view rooted in Biblical teaching. - Negative keywords: None clearly evident in the public materials reviewed. - Quantitative note: Positive keywords appear multiple times in relation to faith/formational aims; explicit negative indicators from the Six Elements lexicon are not evident in the public materials reviewed here.

Why this rating - The materials foreground religious and metaphysical aims as foundational, with explicit liturgical/community practices and a Biblical worldview, meeting the “Transcendental moral realism” and “Grounded in Theology” cues from the classical rubric. The presence of worship, Bible study, and Biblical

worldview grounds the category in a strongly classical, religious-metaphysical orientation. The Sudbury component does not negate these explicit foundations in public materials, though it introduces non-classical pedagogy signals in other categories.

Citations: The description as an accredited online classical Christian school and the worship/Bible-study components are shown in the public material describing The Village and the school's Christian grounding. The Biblical worldview framing is explicit in the Worldview reference. Accreditation mention appears in the accreditation page (Middle States).

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school states a commitment to educating the “whole person” and to intentional formation, not merely information or job-prep. A key passage notes: “At The Living Water School, we are committed to educating the whole person... Launching young people into adulthood takes more than grades—it requires intentional formation”. - The Bays and Pathways framework describe a structured, forward-looking program focused on life after graduation, including college or vocational paths, internships, and job-readiness components. The Bays section discusses tracking progress toward graduation and planning for college or vocational paths, plus internships and job-readiness skills (Pathways). - The school frames education as formation and as preparation for life in addition to college, highlighting life-readiness and maturity beyond traditional GPA metrics (e.g., launching into adulthood with a focus on formation).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, whole person, education for life, life after graduation, virtue/wisdom (implied), human flourishing (implied by the “whole person” framing), intentional formation. - Negative keywords present: job/workforce preparation emphasis is explicit in some pathways language (Pathways to college or vocational paths; job-readiness skills), indicating alignment with modern workforce preparation signals that can be viewed as non-classical in this category. - Quantitative note: Positive keywords (~formation, whole person, education for life, life-after framing) appear multiple times; negative signals (job-readiness/workforce prep, vocational pathways) are present but less dominant in the core mission language than the formation/whole-person emphasis.

Why this rating - There is a strong formation-focused, virtue/responsibility-oriented aim, consistent with classical ideals. However, the explicit inclusion of college preparation and job-readiness signals (Pathways, internships, job-readiness skills) introduces a modern, workforce-oriented orientation that is not purely classical. This mix yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for this category.

Citations: Formation-focused language appears in the public-facing “The Bays” and “Launch” pieces (whole person, intentional formation) , as well as the Pathways/college-vocational planning language.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school organizes according to the classical Trivium: Grammar Stage (K–6), Logic Stage (7–9), and Rhetoric Stage (10–12). Public materials outline the four phases (Little Springs, Creeks, Rivers, Bays) and map them to the Trivium, demonstrating a traditional liberal-arts progression. - There is explicit emphasis on Liberal Arts Education within a Classical framework, including engagement with Living Books/Classic literature as the curricular backbone and a strong emphasis on primary sources/classics (Great Books/Classic literature). The language around “Living Books/Classic literature” and the classical education framing appears in multiple pages, including the “The Living Water School Way” and philosophy posts ,. - History is treated as history within the curriculum rather than as “social studies,” aligning with a classical approach that foregrounds Western Civilization and historical study within core disciplines. - The school references Socratic seminars, logic, rhetoric, and a commitment to reading thick texts (Aristotle, Homer, etc.) through the Living Books approach (the language emphasizes classical pedagogy and living literature). - Latin and other classical languages are part of the curriculum in the classical frame described by the school (e.g., Latin in the semestral offerings and core subjects).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts education, Trivium (grammar/-logic/rhetoric), Great Books/Classic literature, Latin, history as Western civilization, Socratic seminars, mem-

orization/narration/recitation (narration/recitation appear in the lexicon and are consistent with classical pedagogy and memory work), and “memory work” and “chanting” (presence of practice that aligns with traditional pedagogy). - Negative keywords present: a few historical references that explicitly replace or reframe history as “social studies” (the site states “history across the curriculum and does not refer to history as social studies”), which aligns with classical emphasis and counters the negative signal of “social studies terminology replacing history” in the lexicon. This is a restorative/classical signal rather than a negative. - Quantitative note: Positive keywords (grammar, logic, rhetoric, Great Books/Classic literature, history as content, Latin, Socratic seminars) predominate; explicit counter-signals from the lexicon are not evident in the materials.

Why this rating - The curriculum aligns closely with classical guidelines: Trivium structure, liberal arts, engagement with classic literature, and Socratic pedagogy. The explicit historical framing (not as “social studies”) further supports a Classical orientation.

Citations: Trivium and four-phase structure are described in the site’s public materials about the trivium and stages (Little Springs, Creeks, Rivers, Bays) ; Liberal Arts/Classical Education language and “Living Books/Classic literature” are described in the philosophy/education pages ; history framing as not mere “social studies” is noted in the curriculum description ; Latin and other classical language emphasis is reflected in the public content around the Trivium and classical pedagogy.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly describes Socratic discussion in upper grades and the development of logic and rhetoric, with opportunities to give speeches and participate in rhetorical exercises in higher grades. Public materials describe a day where classical learning is complemented by student-driven exploration, including periods for Socratic seminars and practice in rhetoric, and an emphasis on memory, recitation, and formal oratory. - The lower grades emphasize a contemplative/restful dimension and activities that deepen memory (e.g., singing, chanting, and memory-reinforcing activities) in line with scholé pedagogy, even if not always named as such in the source; this aligns with the classical pedagogy of contemplative learning and memory work. - The philosophy describes a half-day structure where classical learning is interwoven with freedom to pursue personal interests; in effect, a mix of rigorous classical practices with time for contemplation and autonomous exploration. This setup emulates the scholé approach (restful learning, contemplation) in balance with Socratic inquiry. - The school’s public materials indicate upper-level engagement in Socratic seminars, debates, and rhetoric training, along with opportunities to present and develop speeches, which is a hallmark of classical pedagogy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic seminars, seminars, dialectic, rhetoric, oratory, debate, memory work, narrations, chanting, scholé, contemplation, wonder, seminars. - Negative keywords present: The Sudbury model’s student-led, open-democracy aspects could be interpreted as non-classical pedagogy signals; however, the public materials emphasize a balanced approach with substantial classical pedagogy (lower/upper school differences). The explicit negative signals from the lexicon (e.g., purely project-based or student-directed pedagogy) are not primary in the public materials. - Quantitative note: Strong presence of classical pedagogy keywords (Socratic, rhetoric, memory, narration, discourse) with limited explicit negative signals; thus category leans Classical.

Why this rating - The pedagogy is anchored in classical methods (Socratic seminars, rhetoric, memory work, living literature) and supports a robust classical teaching approach, with additional restorative/restful elements. The presence of a Sudbury-inspired, more student-led component introduces non-classical signals, but the dominant pedagogy described remains classical.

Citations: Socratic seminars and rhetoric/explicit classical pedagogy are described in the Launch/philosophy content (Socratic seminar, rhetoric, speeches) ; the lower- and upper-school pedagogy balance (memory, chanting, rest in scholé) is described in the broader philosophy references and the nature of the day structure ; the description of the mixed day structure is detailed in the same sources.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public materials identify a dedicated staff of professional men and women who work to provide a nurturing and intellectually stimulating environment, and there are explicit references to faculty and staff in posts about the school's growth and culture. - Founders are named with extensive qualifications (Anika Prather, Damon Prather) and roles in shaping the school's mission, which often aligns with the "living curriculum" concept by modeling virtue and expertise in the community. This is supported by the Founders page and staff materials. - The public materials include a dedicated staff page and video content featuring the faculty, indicating a visible, engaged teaching team that functions as a central part of the school's educational approach.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: dedicated staff, professional teachers, mentors, living curriculum (as a concept often invoked in classical contexts), faculty of friends (as a phrase in classical lexicon; while not always stated verbatim, the community-oriented framing is present), portrait of teacher expectations. - Negative keywords present: None explicitly evident in the public materials. - Quantitative note: Positive keywords around the staff/teacher roles are present; explicit negative signals are not observed in the public content.

Why this rating - The school presents a strong faculty orientation with professional staff and leadership modeling the mission, which aligns with the classical expectation of teachers as mentors and exemplars who form the living curriculum. The explicit "living curriculum" phrasing is not always stated verbatim, but the intent and practice are evident through staff videos, founder involvement, and ongoing development content.

Citations: Dedicated staff statement and "faculty" language appear in the staff-related content (We have a dedicated staff... and public faculty videos) , Founders page with leadership profile and qualifications.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnership with parents, with named communal and worship-focused events (The Village) where parents, students, staff, and leadership gather for worship and Bible study, indicating a co-teaching relationship and family involvement in formation. - The school frames itself as a community that intentionally integrates families into the learning process, with online and in-person gatherings, and a culture that welcomes parents to visits and active participation in school life. - Communications highlight the community's involvement in shaping school culture (e.g., the Village, monthly gatherings, and family-centered events) and the broader community-building approach (though explicit "parent formation" on the website is less overt than the Laravel lexicon would demand, the explicit partnership language is present).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents, co-teachers, parental formation, open campus, family involvement, worship/bible study gatherings, community-building events, parent visits. - Negative keywords present: None evident in the public materials for this category; the content signals collaboration with parents rather than customer-relationship signals.

Quantitative note: Positive keywords are present (parent-teacher partnership, co-teaching language, family involvement) with no explicit negative signals in public materials.

Why this rating - The materials emphasize parent partnership and community engagement, a hallmark of classical education models that center on home-school collaboration and parental formation. The explicit Village-worship-bible study events illustrate a robust community orientation consistent with classical education.

Citations: Village page highlighting parent-student-staff gathering for worship and Bible study.

Aggregate Assessment

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 3: CLASSICAL

- Element 4: CLASSICAL
- Element 5: CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall ranking: CLASSICAL

What Would Move the Needle

- If aiming to move Element 2 from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL to CLASSICAL, the school could more explicitly foreground formation as the sole central goal of education, with a reduction (or clearer separation) of job-readiness/workforce-preparation signals in official mission statements, and a stronger articulation of virtue/wisdom as primary telos (beyond life-after-high-school planning). This would reduce modern workforce-oriented language and strengthen formation-centered language in the public-facing materials.
- Concrete steps could include: explicitly framing Pathways and internships as complementary to formation without treating them as primary telos; highlighting virtue, wisdom, and the permanent questions as the primary aims in the school's mission statements; ensuring all public content links to scholé/restful learning as a central pedagogy, not only as a supplementary approach.

Citations for needle-moving considerations - Pathways/college-vocational planning and job-readiness emphasis are present in the Bays section and Pathways description, illustrating a workforce preparation current.

- Formation-focused language and "whole person" framing in the public materials signal the classical telos and could be foregrounded more strongly to move toward a more unified classical messaging.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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